

About This Resource: This toolkit was designed to give ELL teachers a practical, go-to reference for supporting multilingual learners in virtual classrooms. It is built around a company-wide sheltered instruction model developed from the ground up, drawing on the SIOP model as a research base and adapting it into an eight-strategy framework tailored to the specific context of virtual K–12 instruction.

Differentiation by proficiency level: A dedicated section breaks strategies down by WIDA proficiency level, from Newcomer to Bridging. This was an intentional design choice because a single strategy list flattens the real range of needs in a multilingual classroom. Teachers working with a Newcomer and a Bridging student at the same time need different tools, and the toolkit reflects that.

Addressing misconceptions directly: The myths and clarifications table was included deliberately. Research consistently shows that teacher beliefs about multilingual learners affect instructional decisions as much as pedagogical knowledge does. Rather than leaving misconceptions unaddressed, the toolkit names them directly and offers evidence-based corrections.

Tool integration: MagicSchool AI and Nearpod are embedded within the scaffolding section rather than listed separately as add-ons. This placement was intentional. Positioning tools inside a pedagogical strategy signals that technology serves the learning goal, not the other way around.

ELL Teacher Toolkit

Purpose.....	1
Sheltered Instruction Model.....	2
1. Plan with Purpose.....	2
2. Connect to What Students Know.....	3
3. Make Content Clear.....	4
4. Support Language Development.....	5
5. Scaffold for Success.....	6
Magic School AI.....	8
Nearpod.....	8
6. Promote Student Interaction.....	8
7. Put Learning into Action.....	9
8. Check Understanding Often.....	9
Proficiency Level Strategies.....	10
Newcomers (Beginner Level):.....	10
Emerging (Low-Intermediate Level):.....	10
Developing (Intermediate Level):.....	11
Expanding (High-Intermediate Level):.....	11
Bridging (Advanced Level):.....	11
ELL Core Teacher Expectations.....	11
Common Misconceptions about MLs.....	12
FAQs and Troubleshooting.....	13
Glossary of ELL Terms.....	13

Sheltered Instruction Model

Sheltered instruction is designed to make academic content accessible to multilingual learners while they build their English language skills. While the approach values and sometimes incorporates students' first languages—for example, to clarify a concept, build background, or affirm identity—it is **primarily conducted in English**. Instruction, materials, and classroom communication are delivered in English, **with a strong focus on making that language comprehensible** through visuals, modeling, repetition, and interaction. **Translations of full lessons or materials are not typically used**; instead,

the goal is to support students in understanding and using academic English within the content area.

Here are **8 practical, research-informed strategies** you can apply in your virtual classroom. They include:

1. Plan with Purpose

Set clear goals for what students will learn and how they'll use language to show their understanding. Every lesson should include **both a content objective** (what students are learning) and a **language objective** (how students will use language to access and demonstrate their learning).

Content objectives tell students what they'll learn—like solving a problem or explaining an idea.

Language objectives explain how they'll use English to do it—like writing, discussing, or using specific vocabulary.

Stating both helps MLs access content and build language skills together. Make them clear, post them on screen, and refer back to them during the middle and end of class.

Beginning of Class	• Say it clearly: “Today we'll practice using past tense verbs in a paragraph.” • Write it on the board • Explain in simple terms • Connect it to content goals
Middle of Class	• Remind students of the language goal • Model how to use the language • Provide supports like: ◦ Sentence frames ◦ Word banks ◦ Visuals or anchor charts
End of Class	• Review the objective during closure or exit ticket • Ask students to demonstrate understanding • Quick summary • Exit response • Highlight progress and next steps

2. Connect to What Students Know

Make lessons meaningful by linking them to students' backgrounds and experiences.

Multilingual learners, especially newcomers, often arrive with different educational and cultural backgrounds. Some may have experienced interrupted schooling or are unfamiliar with the academic language used in U.S. classrooms. Even MLs born in the U.S. may not speak English at home and might lack exposure to key academic vocabulary.

Before we jump into new content, it's essential to connect learning to what students already know. For multilingual learners, this step helps bridge the gap between their experiences and the academic language they're building.

To support all MLs, **scaffold lessons by building background knowledge and introducing key language**. This helps provide context and prepares students to engage with new content.

Strategies to Support MLs:

- **Connect to students' lived experiences** to introduce the topic and make learning relevant.
- **Teach and reinforce key vocabulary** at the start of a unit and throughout.
- **Focus on academic vocabulary**, including:
 - Subject-specific terms (e.g., plot, divide, hypothesis)
 - Cross-curricular language (e.g., describe, conclude, analyze)
 - Use bilingual glossaries to reinforce new vocabulary

Understanding academic vocabulary—especially in directions and assessments—is crucial. For example, students may struggle with a question if they don't understand the word "evaluate."

- **Teach word parts** such as Greek and Latin roots and affixes to help students make sense of unfamiliar words.
(Example: The root *photo-* means "light," which helps with words like *photosynthesis*, *photography*, and *photogenic*.)

3. Make Content Clear

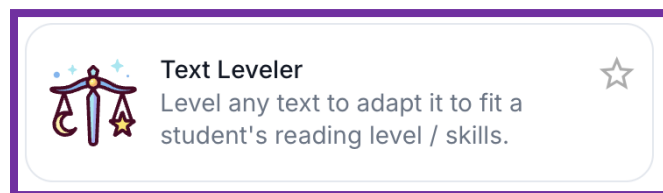
Use visuals, examples, and plain language to support comprehension. One of the most powerful ways we can support multilingual learners is by making our content **comprehensible**-- meaning students can follow along, even if they don't understand every single word-- making your teaching clear and accessible for all students.

Adapt your speech to match students' language levels:

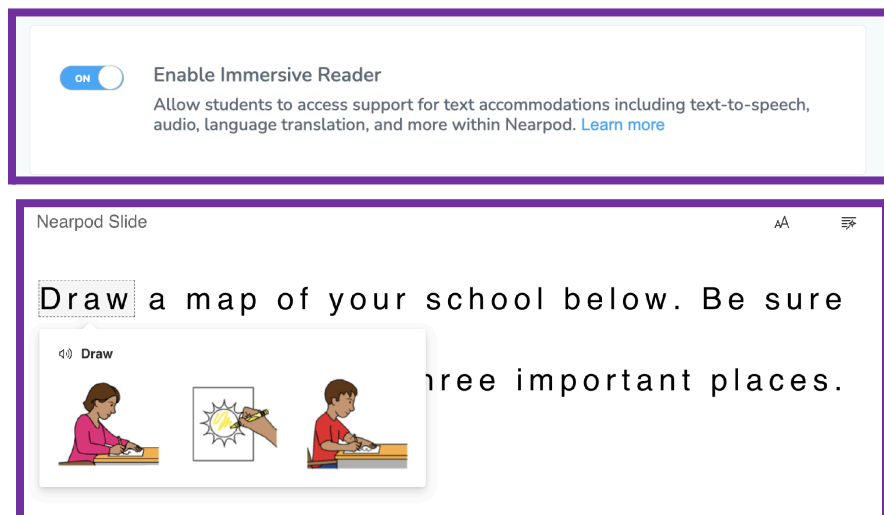
- Speak clearly and slowly
- Use meaningful pauses
- Enunciate words
- Repeat and paraphrase often
- Use simple sentence structures (e.g., subject-verb-object) for beginners
- Check regularly to make sure students understand

Leverage technology:

- Use tools like **MagicSchool's Text Leveler** to modify reading passages to students' language levels. Teachers can adjust the complexity of texts to match their students' proficiency levels, making content accessible without diluting meaning.



- In **Nearpod**, enable the **immersive Reader** to *read-aloud* slides, word pictures and word translations.



- Add **captions** to videos whenever possible and ensure **Zoom captions** are turned on during live sessions.

Give clear instructions for academic tasks:

- Explain what students need to do, in what order, and how to turn it in
- Provide **written instructions** in addition to oral ones
- **Model** the task so students can see what's expected

4. Support Language Development

Focus on key vocabulary and give students the tools they need to use academic English. Helping multilingual learners succeed starts with thoughtful planning. By embedding consistent strategies into your lessons, you support both content understanding and language development.

Use a mix of strategies:

- **Cognitive:** Have students preview texts, take notes, highlight key vocabulary, and set learning goals.
- **Metacognitive:** Encourage predictions, self-questioning, summarizing, and monitoring understanding.
- **Language-focused:** Teach grammar and sentence patterns in context. Use reading strategies (skimming, scanning) and help students use context clues and visuals to make meaning.

Be intentional with language:

- **Frontload vocabulary** with visuals, realia, and examples before starting new content.
- **Model grammar** through content (e.g., past tense in history, modals in science predictions).
- Use clear, consistent instructions with visual supports and multiple inputs (spoken, written, gestures).

Explicit Vocabulary Instruction to Support Language Development

Explicit instruction and regular repetition and practice of new vocabulary, both content and academic, is crucial for MLs to succeed, especially in preparation for assessments.

Content vocabulary refers to subject-specific terms (e.g., *mass*, *matter*, *density*) often introduced during instruction. While all students may encounter these words, MLs often need extra time and practice to internalize them—especially since many have meanings

beyond their academic use. Use the **Content Vocabulary List** in your course or Teacher Resources to support instruction.

Academic vocabulary includes words commonly found in directions, test questions, and classroom discourse (e.g., *analyze, explain, define*). These words are essential for understanding academic tasks but are rarely taught explicitly. MLs may struggle not with the task itself, but with understanding what is being asked. The **Academic Vocabulary List** is a helpful tool for building this understanding.

Vocabulary resources are also available in the **Language Essentials** slides, including graphic organizer templates that can be used during your lessons with any vocabulary that you choose. Printable versions are also available. Encourage students to save their vocabulary journals and graphic organizers for review.

In addition, Nearpod houses **language resources** and **Newcomer resources** designed to support language development across content areas.

5. Scaffold for Success

Scaffold tasks and model strategies to help students process new ideas, like using tools like graphic organizers and think alouds. Scaffolding is about providing the right amount of support so multilingual learners can access challenging content while building confidence and independence.

As you introduce new ideas or complex tasks, break them into manageable steps. Use tools like **graphic organizers or sentence frames** to help students organize their thinking visually and model your thought process with **think-alouds** so they can see how to approach a task.

These strategies don't simplify the learning, rather, they make learning **accessible to the student**. Over time, you'll gradually remove the scaffolds as students gain the skills to do it on their own.

Use these 10 scaffolds for any class:

1. **Graphic Organizers**- Help students structure their thinking (Venn diagrams, story maps, cause-effect charts).
2. **Sentence Frames & Starters**- Provide partial sentences to support academic language use. (Note: This is a support strategy, not a fill-in-the-blank CFU.)
Example: "One reason is ____, because ____."
3. **Word Banks**- Offer key vocabulary students can use in speaking or writing tasks.

4. **Think-Alouds-** Model how to approach a reading or writing task by saying your thought process out loud.
5. **Visuals & Realia-** Use images, videos, or real objects to clarify new content or vocabulary.
6. **Chunking Texts-** Break longer readings or tasks into smaller parts, checking for understanding after each one.
7. **Gestures and Body Language-** Reinforce meaning non-verbally to help comprehension.
8. **Peer Models & Partner Work-** Pair students with peers who can demonstrate academic language or help clarify instructions.
9. **Color Coding-** Use colors to show connections (e.g., underlining claims in blue, evidence in green).
10. **Guided Questions-** Provide step-by-step questions to lead students toward deeper understanding.

Leverage MagicSchool AI and Nearpod to scaffold in your class!

Magic School AI

Using Magic School's tools will cut your admin time while providing endless scaffolding opportunities for your students. Here are a couple of our favorite tools:

- ✓ **Sentence Starter:** Provides structured sentence starters to support MLs in speaking and writing, helping them express their thoughts clearly.
- ✓ **Text Scaffolder:** Adds scaffolding elements like summaries, sentence stems, or key questions to help MLs understand texts.
- ✓ **Assignment Scaffolder:** Breaks assignments into manageable steps for MLs.

Check out the **MagicSchool AI for MLs** on the Teacher SharePoint for more tips!

Nearpod

Use Nearpod to get your students involved in their learning. Lessons in Nearpod incorporate various functions to get students engaged in their learning. Check out:

- ✓ **Draw It Activities:** Students draw, label, or highlight directly on images, diagrams, or blank canvases to demonstrate understanding.
- ✓ **VR and 3D Models:** Immersive tools that let students explore virtual field trips or interactive 3D objects to deepen content knowledge.
- ✓ **Time to Climb:** A gamified quiz where students race to the top by answering questions correctly, making learning fun and competitive.

Check out **Nearpod for MLs** on the Teacher SharePoint for more tips!

6. Promote Student Interaction

Use your platform tools to get students talking, collaborating, and sharing ideas. Group students *intentionally* to facilitate conversations, collaboration, and peer support. Implement grouping configurations that vary between homogenous and heterogenous, depending on the students' literacy and language skills. Grouping is often driven by **language proficiency levels**, **literacy development**, and **targeted support needs**.

- Use **flexible groups** based on language data (WIDA scores, running records, formative assessments).
- Group students strategically for targeted instruction (guided reading, writing workshops, vocabulary development).
- **Mix English proficiency levels** to promote peer modeling and language growth.
- Use **homogeneous groups** for skill-building in the native language.
- Use **heterogeneous groups** to encourage collaboration and academic discussion.

MLs may struggle to answer opinion questions due to both language barriers and cultural norms. In some educational settings, students aren't accustomed to being asked for their opinions or may fear giving a “wrong” answer. U.S. classrooms’ emphasis on open discussion can be unfamiliar and intimidating.

To support MLs in sharing their thoughts:

- Clarify that opinions won't be graded or judged.
- Ask students what someone else might think (a character, public figure, etc.) to reduce personal pressure.
- Avoid cold-calling; offer private or anonymous response options, like the **private chat or polls**.
- Provide **multiple ways for students to participate**, such as group chat or speaking out loud. Allowing choice in how to interact lowers anxiety and increases engagement.
- Use sentence frames and word banks to help students build responses. You can find many sentence frames in the **Language Essentials slides**, with both general and subject-specific options available.
- Use strategies like **think-pair-share** to give students time to process and respond.

7. Put Learning into Action

Plan engaging tasks with real-world connections that require students to use what they've learned *and* practice their new language skills. To truly internalize new content and language, students need chances to *use* what they've learned in meaningful ways. Design tasks that are **engaging, purposeful**, and connected to the **real world**.

Think beyond worksheets—create projects, role-plays, or problem-solving tasks that mirror real-life situations. Whether it's writing a letter, recording a weather report, or planning a community event, these activities motivate students to apply both content knowledge and language skills in context.

8. Check Understanding Often

Use quick, informal checks to see what's working and where to adjust. When giving summative assessments, make sure they are accessible for students, so they can show their understanding of the content! When assessing multilingual learners, remember they're demonstrating content knowledge while working in a new language. To ensure they can show what they know, provide the right supports:

- **Ensure appropriate accommodations** are available for summative assessments—such as *extended time*, *bilingual glossaries*, *translated directions*, or *alternative formats*—based on students' language levels and accommodations plans.
- **Review key and academic vocabulary** before assessments in context, with repeated exposure and varied practice.
- **Give clear, consistent feedback** on both content and language. Highlight what students did well and what to improve.
- **Model correct language use** in your feedback. For example, if a student says, "The children are confusing," you might respond, "Yes, the children are confused because they're lost," reinforcing correct grammar while affirming their ideas.

It's also essential to regularly observe how language is developing and **adjust instruction accordingly** to meet students' evolving needs.

- Use real-time observations to adjust instruction and give timely feedback that helps students reflect and take ownership of their learning.
- Build in self-assessment and reflection opportunities.
- Encourage growth by allowing assignment revisions for full credit or letting students use notes on assessments to earn back partial credit.

Proficiency Level Strategies

Newcomers (Beginner Level):

Visual Support and gestures

Use highly visual materials such as pictures, diagrams, realia (real objects), and gestures to convey meaning. Provide written text with simple, short sentences and translations when possible. Use sentence frames like "I see..." or "This is a..." to support comprehension without overwhelming the student with too much text or complex language. It allows students to focus on the content while acquiring basic vocabulary and phrases.

Emerging (Low-Intermediate Level):

Bilingual Scaffolding

Allow students to use their native language (L1) for initial comprehension and then gradually transition to English. Provide side-by-side translations of key concepts or vocabulary, use bilingual dictionaries, or allow the use of Google Translate. The purpose is to bridge gaps in understanding and support vocabulary acquisition while students are still building basic proficiency in English. This supports content comprehension without halting academic progress.

Developing (Intermediate Level):

Guided Note-Taking

At the developing stage, students are ready to engage more deeply with academic content but still benefit from targeted support in organizing and retaining information. Introduce **guided note-taking strategies** such as fill-in-the-blank notes, graphic organizers, or concept maps to help students capture key ideas while focusing on comprehension rather than transcription.

Expanding (High-Intermediate Level):

Collaborative Learning

Pair or group students with more proficient English speakers. Use project-based learning, where students work together on assignments or presentations, allowing the high-intermediate ML student to practice both content knowledge and language skills in a social setting. Provide practice in academic language (both oral and written) through interaction. Group work encourages speaking and listening in a real-world context while reinforcing content knowledge.

Bridging (Advanced Level):

Academic Language Development

Focus on refining students' use of **academic English**, particularly the complex structures used in content-specific writing and discussion. Use debates, research projects, and writing tasks that challenge students to use precise academic vocabulary and grammar. The goal is to transition students from conversational to academic proficiency, ensuring they can meet the demands of higher-level coursework and standardized assessments, and effectively communicate complex ideas.

Common Misconceptions about MLs

Working with MLs requires understanding not only their language development but also the common misunderstandings that can impact how we support them. Misconceptions about language learning, academic ability, and student behavior can unintentionally lead to lower expectations or missed opportunities for growth. The table below highlights several common misconceptions about MLs and offers clarifications to guide more effective instruction.

Myth	Clarification
ESL and bilingual education are the same.	Both support English learners, but ESL focuses on English instruction, while bilingual education uses both languages to foster bilingualism.
I can't teach students who speak a different language.	You don't need to speak their language. Scaffolding and strong teaching strategies can bridge the gap.
ML students need easier work.	MLs need access to rigorous content with appropriate supports—not simplified work. Lowering rigor may cause disengagement or delays.
Translation is the best support.	Translated materials help in the moment but don't promote long-term English acquisition . Teach students to use translation tools and English dictionaries.
Strong speaking skills = no support needed.	Students may speak well but still struggle with reading and writing. Language proficiency varies across domains.
ML students aren't trying to learn.	Language learning is mentally exhausting. "Shutdown" behaviors often signal overload, not lack of effort. Brain breaks and L1 use help.
ML students don't want to participate—give them written work instead.	Delayed responses may be due to culture, language anxiety, or fear of mistakes. Use wait time, think-pair-share, and written prep to build confidence.
Poor grammar = lack of understanding.	Don't judge understanding based on grammar. Focus on clarity over correctness—only correct errors that interfere with meaning.

Glossary of ELL Terms

- **ML** = Multilingual learner (recently adopted terminology by WIDA)
- **ELL** = English language learner
- **ESL** = English as a second language
- **EL** = English learner
- **EB** = Emergent Bilingual (Texas)

- **L1** = first language
- **L2** = second language
- **Language Proficiency** = mastery of a language including productive and receptive skills; often broken down into four main domains of reading, writing, speaking, and listening
- **Target Language** = the language students are learning (in this case, English)
- **Newcomer (Program)** = student who has recently arrived in the United States and may speak little to no English; programs to meet transitional needs of newly arrived immigrants
- **ESL Education** = students may have diverse linguistic and cultural backgrounds, but only English is used for instruction and the teacher may not speak any of the same languages as the students; the focus is on English language acquisition (see here for a comparison of ESL and bilingual instruction)
- **Bilingual Instruction** = program where ELL students with the same language background are grouped together and instructed in two languages (English and their native language); English language lessons are not included
- **Dual Language** = bilingual programs intended for students to gain proficiency in two languages simultaneously; often contains both native English speakers and speakers of other languages
- **Sheltered Instruction** = instructional approach to teach *content* in English in a way that is linguistically accessible to ELL students using various methods
- **SIOP** – (Sheltered Instruction Observation Protocol) a specific form of sheltered instruction that has been widely adopted and may be referenced by school leaders
- **WIDA** = (World-class Instructional Design and Assessment) most widely used standards for multilingual learners in the United States
- **ACCESS Exam** = WIDA proficiency assessment widely used for placement across the U.S.